



**Fastest, Highest,
Strongest: (From L-R)
Sprinter Noah Lyles,
pole vaulter Armand
Duplantis and
weightlifter Lasha
Talakhadze celebrate
their respective
victories at the Paris
Olympics**

competition. At the Tokyo Olympic Games, Lasha smashed three of (his own) world records to win gold. He lifted a total of 488kg – 47 kilos more than his nearest rival. No one across measurable events comes close to that sort of dominance.

When he competed, no one doubted he would win. There would just be this sense of awe as Lasha waited until everyone else in the competition was done. Then he would begin to lift. He would make three clean lifts first in the snatch, then retreat to the private zone in the warm-up hall.

He would then wait for the other lifters to be done with their clean and jerk and fight between themselves for the minor medals before he would swagger out having posted what would seem like impossible numbers. He would load the bar with an unreasonable amount of red, yellow and green iron discs – unreasonable to all but him. Then with no fuss, he'd lift that weight like Atlas over his head. The question for his competitors wasn't whether he'd beat them. It was how much he

would beat them by.

That was Lasha at his best. He was at his best for a very long time. He's still very good. But Lasha is 30 now – coming close to the age where explosiveness and speed begin to decline. When he came to Paris though, there was this strange sense of mortality about him. A couple of years ago, he very nearly died on the operation table after going into a coma following an adverse reaction to anaesthesia for a routine procedure to treat nasal polyps.

He came back from that to win another World Championship gold in 2023 but wear and tear have taken their toll. He injured his knees, which forced him to miss the 2024 European Championships. He was still the gold medal favourite for the Paris Games, but no one expected him to lift a total of 500 kilos – an impossible target no one but Lasha could have even dreamed of lifting.

When Lasha made his appearance on the weightlifting stage for the first time on the evening of August 10, the Georgian Colossus stood out even among a pack of some of the

biggest and strongest men on the planet. At 6-foot-6-inches – head and shoulders above his rivals – he is listed as weighing 171kg.

Like most years, Lasha waited until most of the competition was done with snatch. He was to start at 210kg – the most he has ever started an Olympic competition with. This seemed like the old Lasha. But then suddenly both old rivals Gor Minasyan and Varazdat Lalyan put up identical lifts. All three made their lifts. Lasha increased the weight on the bar to 215 kilos. He made it but once again Lalyan followed. Minasyan went a step further. He loaded a total of 216 kilos on the bar and made it. For the first time in nearly a decade, Lasha wasn't in the lead at a weightlifting competition.

Then the unthinkable happened. Lasha posted a mark of 220kg. And for the first time in what seemed like forever, his arms buckled. The weight fell. The crowd gasped. Lasha slinked backstage. Minasyan attempted the same. He could have potentially gone five kilos clear at the top. But he failed too. He still had the